

CONCEPT OF ENVIRONMENTALISM

STUDY MATERIAL FOR THE STUDENTS OF SEMESTER ONE, PAPER ONE.

BY

Dr. Arvind Adityaraj

Professor & Ex. Head

Department of Political Science

College of Commerce, Arts & Science, Patna.

Introduction;

Environmentalism is a heterogeneous worldwide social and political movement, which champions the preservation, sustainable management and restoration of the natural environment in an endeavour to fulfill human wants, including spiritual and social needs, as well as for its own sake. To achieve the foregoing targets, environmentalists generally call for social change, public policy reforms and changes in the behaviours of individuals, governments and private firms and organizations. The three-pronged objectives of the environmental movement are; nature worship, a commitment to maintain the health of the natural system and identification of humanity as a part of and not detached to the ecosystem. The major concerns that alarm the environmentalists are the swift increase in the global population and consequently rising demands for natural resources and energy and growing pressures on natural systems as well as short sightedness, acquisitiveness and an increasing alienation of the post-industrialized humanity from the natural environment. The environmentalist movement is represented by a wide range of non-governmental organizations (N.G.Os) from the global to grass-root level and includes individuals from the corporate world, religious and spiritual people and government officials.

The world's oldest major religion Hinduism begins with Vedic scriptures called *Aranyakas* (forest books), as they were written by sages living in the forests. The modern Indian poet and Nobel Laureate Rabindranath Tagore wrote; "The cultures of the forest has fueled the culture of India"¹. Hinduism and Buddhism teach the sacredness of nature. Both the religions are based on the concept of reincarnation, a "cycle of life, death and rebirth". Hinduism teaches that the environment is sacred, because of the intertwining of the natural world and the divine. In Buddhism, there is an interdependence of all life forms. Everything is in essence, one with the rest of the world². Three to five thousand years ago, in China Taoism and Confucianism explain and ask people to follow the pattern of nature. Greek mythology also links the concepts of justice and nature. For instance, Themis, the goddess of law was the daughter of Gaia, the goddess of earth. In 256 B.C. the Indian king Asoka Piyadasi of Magadha Empire issued seven pillar edicts, one of which states; "Twenty six years after my coronation various animals were declared protected – parrots, mainas, wild ducks bats tortoises....."³.

The concept of environmentalism includes totality of all components surrounding men. While describing “polity” as the best practicable state, Greek philosopher Aristotle regarded “imitation of nature” as the key to understanding life⁴. Romantic poets wrote of the natural world as the source of moral and aesthetic value and stressed the supposed unity between humanity and nature which the process of rapid industrialization has broken down. Such back to the nature view is clearly a part of the contemporary green ideology. Similarly, craft oriented thinkers such as William Morris (1834-96) with an aesthetic regard to non-human natural world advocated closeness to nature as an antidote to what he regarded as the ugliness of industrial life and pressed the value of countryside against urban life.

According to the Environmental Pollution Panel of the U.S. President’s Science Advisory Committee the term environment means “the sum of all social, biological, physical and chemical factors which compose the surroundings of man”. The Encyclopaedia Britannica defines the term environmentalism as “a political and ethical movement that seeks to improve and protect the quality of the natural environment through changes to environmentally harmful human activities: through the adoption of forms of political, economic and social organizations that are thought to be necessary for or at least conducive to, the benign treatment of the environment by humans; and through a reassessment of humanity’s relationship with nature”⁵. A simpler definition of environmentalism calls it “a social movement that seeks to influence the political process by lobbying, education, activism and setting an example in order to protect natural resources and ecosystem. Some of the issues of concern for the environmental movement are pollution, species extinction, waste reduction, recycling, global warming, ozone depletion and genetically engineered crops”⁶.

A Brief Survey of the History of Environmentalism;

While making a survey of the history of mankind one comes across several occasions when governments have passed laws to safeguard human health from environmental degradation. In the year A.D. 80, the Roman Senate passed legislation to protect the city’s supply of clean water for drinking and bathing. In the 14th century, the British government stopped the burning of coal in London and the disposal of waste into waterways. William Penn, the Quaker leader of the English colony of Pennsylvania ordered in 1681 that an acre of forest be preserved for every five acres cleared for settlement. In the following century Benjamin Franklin led various campaigns to curtail the dumping of waste. In the 19th century in the midst of the Industrial Revolution, the English government passed several resolutions to reduce the disastrous effects of coal burning and chemical manufacture on public health and environment⁷.

Between 1730 and 1850, the Industrial Revolution sparked unprecedented wave of forest clearance and land drainage. This assault on nature led to occasional reactions from some odd individuals. In 1854 American philosopher Henry David Thoreau (1817-62) published his classic *Walden* in which he narrated his two years living experiment in woods near a pond called Walden in Massachusetts, where he spent his time walking, reading and growing food. In this book he described the harmony that human can experience when living with nature. Taking this leaf out of Thoreau’s book Scottish born visionary John Muir (1838-1914) together with Robert U. Johnson, successfully lobbied congress for the creation of a preserve in the Yosemite Valley in

California and in 1890 Yosemite National Park was born. Shortly after in 1892, Muir along with Johnson founded the *Sierra Club*. Through the Club, Muir successfully used his literary skill to encourage the U.S. government to protect some of the great wilderness of the country.

Inspired by nature lovers like Thoreau and Muir, the western world became conscious the environment degradation. In 1864 George Perkins Marsh published *Man and Justice*. The book described severe erosion and loss of watersheds caused by rapid deforestation, particularly in the ancient Mediterranean world⁸. In the last quarter of the nineteenth century, scientists, federal officials and even timber companies recognized that rapid cutting of forests must be reduced and regulated. The result was the passing of the Forest reserve Act of 1891⁹. at about this time, national parks were declared in Australia, New Zealand and Canada. In 1893, Britain founded its first conservation based organization “The Royal society for the Protection of Birds” and in the following year “The National Trust” was established.

In the year 1905, the U.S. president Theodore Roosevelt created the U.S. Forest Service and named Crifford Pinchot as the Chief Forester, who had studied forestry in France and after his return in 1890 was shocked to see the abuse of national resources in the U.S. Pinchot set up a system of management for national resources that focused on selective harvest, rather than indiscriminate plunder. Large portion of land were brought under public ownership and made into National Forests, which the Forest Service managed¹⁰. Pinchot and Muir were both friends with President Theodore Roosevelt and represented two sub-groups of the environmental movement; Preservationist and Conservationist respectively. Muir supported restrictive strategy; setting up national preserve isolated from human activity while Pinchot advocated wise use policy, where natural resources were used but not abused. Conservation versus preservation is one of the central issues in the environmental debate today¹¹.

The cause of the decimated species, like the North American buffalo prompted William Hornaday (1854-1937) to write in 1913 *Our Vanishing Wildlife*. Hornaday was one of the first conservationists to draw attention to the plight of endangered wildlife¹². Another important name associated with the development of the environmental movement, which deserves to be mentioned is Aldo Leopold, who worked in the U.S. Forest service for 19 years. His posthumous work *A Sand County Almanac* (1948), published a year after his death, is a collection of his essays in which he has tried to explore the complex relationship between organisms and their environment. He introduced a new branch of the environmental movement ‘ecology’, which focused more on the scientific aspects of the natural world¹².

The works of these environmental activists and authors created awareness for global cooperation in conserving the earth’s natural assets and led to the establishment of the “International Union for the Protection of Nature”. Which later became the International Union for the conservation of Nature (I.U.C.N.) in 1948. The I.U.C.N. had members representing governments, institutions and associations as well as international groups and non-governmental organizations.

Contemporary Environmentalism; Within a hundred years, a handful of concerned people had done much to raise awareness of environmental destruction. In the 1960s, environmentalism became an important political and intellectual movement in the west and concern for the environment was galvanized into an organized force. A revolutionary

moment in the history of contemporary environmental movement occurred in 1962 with the publication of Rachel Carson's *Silent Spring*, in which she describes an imaginary environmental catastrophe. Carson emphasized the fragility of ecological relationship and argued for the embedding of human beings in these relationships rather than beyond them and called traditional notions of scientific progress into question. The book alternates between naturalist essays and scientific study and documents the threats chemical pesticides posed to the humans and the plants. Carson was a scientist and writer who began her career with the U.S. Bureau of Fisheries and was elevated to the position of the editor-in-chief of all publications for the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service. Much of her earlier works were related to the sea. She spoke out against chemical companies and the government agencies that followed the policy of pest eradication campaigns at the cost of natural environment. *Silent Spring* was an enormous success and earned Carson a place as a key figure in environmental history. It started an era of environmental protection heralded by bans on chemical pesticides (President John F. Kennedy set up a commission to study pesticides, resulting in a ban on D.D.T. in 1972), legislations for improving air and water quality and the establishment of the Environment Protection Agency¹⁴.

The popular environmental movement began with a number of high profile events, which roused public awareness of environmental issues in the 1960s. The important environmental events, which received great attention were: on 31 January 1969, an oil spill took place off the coast of Santa Barbara, California, on 22 June, the same year, the Cuyahoga river in Cleveland, Ohio, caught fire because of the chemicals floating on the river surface and so on.¹⁵

The year 1971 saw the establishment of two of the most important environmental pressure groups: Friends of the Earth and Green Peace. These Non Governmental Organizations (N.G.Os.) introduced flagship campaigns for threatened species like pandas and tigers and they informed the world of the trade in elephant ivory, rhino horn and seal fur. In the same year thirty four countries (now nearly hundred members) signed the "Convention on Wetlands of International Importance Especially as Water-flow Habitat" at Ramsar, Iran. This agreement came into force in 1975 and it recognized the important role of wetland in maintaining the ecological equilibrium and required all signatory countries to designate at least one protected wetland area. In 1972 the report *Limit to Growth* published by the Club of Rome unfolded a futuristic scenario in which mankind will run out of the non-renewable resources before the year 2072 with the most probable result being "a rather sudden and uncontrollable decline in both population and industrial capacity" if the economic development continues with the present pace¹⁶.

The First Earth Summit Meet (1972); The first of the ten yearly "Earth Summits", generally considered to be primary defining event of international environmentalism was held in 1972 in Stockholm, Sweden (officially known as the United Nations Conference on the Human Environment). The summit was initiated by the developed world to address the environmental effects of industrialization and was attended by 113 nations. The major outcomes of the conference were as follows;

- (a) 26 principles of the Declaration of the conference.
- (b) An Action Plan for the Human Environment and an Environment Fund.
- (c) Establishment of the United Nations Environment Programme (U.N.E.P.) with its headquarter in Nairobi. It was designed to promote environmental practices

throughout the world. It has also coordinated the subsequent Earth Summits. Through its network of regional and national offices U.N.E.P. helps countries to strengthen their capacity to address environmental challenges at global, national and community levels.

The First Earth Summit recognized the failure of mankind to manage biosphere and called for the minimization of gaps between developed and developing countries. After the conclusion of this conference, a great number of these countries introduced issues concerning environment in their social and political agendas and many governmental and non-governmental organizations were created.

The Second Earth Summit Meet (1982); In 1982, with the renewed spell of cold war at its height due to the Soviet Union's intervention in Afghanistan, the second 'Earth Summit' held in Nairobi, Kenya, did not leave any significant imprint on the landscape of environmental movement.

In 1983, the United Nations General Assembly created the "U.N. World Commission on Environment and Development" with Dr. Gro Harlem Brundtland, the first woman Prime Minister of Norway as its chairperson. In 1987 she published the "Brundtland Report" and coined the term "Sustainable Development". The Report combines environmental and economic considerations and defines the term sustainability as; "Development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generation to meet their own needs"¹⁷. Sustainability henceforth became the buzzword in the environmental arena. (For details see the sub section.....on Sustainable Development).

During the 1980s the trans boundary effects of environmental pollution triggered by the effects of the 1986 accident at the nuclear power plant at Chernobyl in Ukraine, then a part of the erstwhile Soviet Union, opened the doors for negotiations on several international environmental conventions. The same year witnessed two international agreements- the "Convention on Early Notification of a Nuclear Accident" and the "Convention on Assistance in the Case of Nuclear Accident or Radiological Emergency" to ensure notification and assistance in the event of a nuclear accident. In the following decade a "Convention on Nuclear Safety, 1994 established incentives for countries to adopt basic standards for the safe operation of land-based nuclear power plants.

The Third Earth Summit Meet (1992); The 1992 'Earth Summit' in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil was unprecedented both in its size and the scope of its concerns. It aimed to outline an agenda for future action on environmental and developmental issues, which would bring sustainable development closer through integrating and balancing environmental, social and economic concerns. The summit witnessed the signing of five multilateral agreements, two of which- "The Convention on Biological Diversity" and "The Framework Convention on Climate Change" are legally binding for all participating parties. The other three documents are non-binding statements: "The Rio Declaration" setting 27 principles to guide international action on the basis of global responsibility towards sustainable development, "The Agenda 21" providing a broad-ranging programme of actions in various sectors and "The Statement on Forest Principles" with 15 principles for the protection and more sustainable use of global forest resources. Following the Rio Earth Summit for additional multilateral environmental agreements were adopted that can be regarded as Rio outcomes-

1. Convention to Combat Desertification
2. Rotterdam Convention on Prior Informed Consent Procedure for Certain Hazardous Chemicals and Pesticides in International Trade.
3. Convention on Persistent Organic Pollutants.
4. The Straddling and Migrating Fish Stocks Agreements.

The Kyoto Protocol; In 1995 the Inter-governmental panel on climate change, which was established by the World Meteorological Organization and the U.N.E.P. to study changes in Earth's temperature concluded that "The balance of evidence suggests a discernible human influence on global climate"¹⁸. Climate change, which has of late become a central focus of the Green Movement, is caused by global warming, an anthropogenic phenomenon. The Oxford Dictionary defines the term as "increase in the temperature of the earth's atmosphere caused by the greenhouse effect". Carbon dioxide gas released from burning fossil fuels like coal, oil and natural gas that were formed from the remains of plant material deposited during the earth's carboniferous period, was causing the earth's atmosphere to heat up. Global warming is caused as the heat released after the burning of these fossil fuel get trapped along with the sun's heat in the earth's atmosphere. The global warming would result in the melting of the polar ice caps and the subsequent rise in the sea levels.

In the year 1987 in Kyoto Japan, a conference of the signatories to the "Framework Convention on Climate Change" adopted the "Kyoto Protocol", which featured binding emission targets for developed countries. The "Kyoto Protocol" required the signatory countries to cut carbon dioxide emissions by five percent between 2008 and 2012. On February 16, 2005 the "Kyoto Protocol" officially became effective with a majority of the countries ratifying it (Russia ratified it on 5 November 2004).

The greatest efforts to reduce global warming are today taking place in Europe. Britain has agreed to cut carbon emission by sixty percent over fifty years, Holland by eighty percent in forty years and Germany by fifty percent in fifty years¹⁹.

During this period "Eco-tourism" was being proposed as a great new way to save the world's environment. The potential being high as in the year 1999 almost one tenth of the world's population (664 million people traveled to another country. This could be a good deal to humans and wild life. For example- whale watching is worth Pound 700 million to the tourist industry and to promote this in a big way would certainly give a death blow to the environment damaging macabre trade of whale killing. However, according to some people the potential of eco-tourism as something environment friendly is debatable as damage the tourists do to the environment outweigh the benefits they bring. They encourage the development of new resorts in wild places and increase the amount of aviation fuel burned.

The Fourth Earth Summit (2002); "The World Summit on Sustainable Development" or the fourth "Earth Summit" was held in Johannesburg, South Africa from 26 August to 4 September 2002. Its goal according to the U.N. General Assembly Resolution was to hold a ten year review of the 1992 Earth Summit and to revive global commitment to sustainable development. It was therefore informally nicknamed "Rio+10". 65000 politicians, numerous N.G.Os and media people attended the Earth Summit. U.S. President George W. Bush decided not to attend or send a representative under the influence of certain lobbies such as "Americans for Tax Reforms", "American Enterprise Institute" and "Competitive Enterprise Institute"²⁰.

At the Johannesburg Summit the focus shifted to the social and development agenda and more particularly poverty eradication, sanitation and health. The Plan of Implementation recognized poverty as a running theme, linked to its multiple dimensions, from access to energy, water and sanitation to the equitable sharing of the benefits of the bio-diversity. Modest commitments on measures to contribute to the recovery of fish-stocks, action on chemical and potential benefit-sharing regime under the “Convention on Biological Diversity” (C.B.D.). Major areas of development included: time bound targets for renewable energy, energy subsidies, natural resources degradation, Rio Principle 7 & 15, i.e, common but differentiated responsibilities and precautionary approach respectively, finance and globalization and the Kyoto Protocol.

The previous summits had been dominated by the United States and the European Union, but in Johannesburg the developing countries had become evermore vocal- demanding their interests be given greater consideration. However, this Summit has been roundly condemned by the environmentalists claiming that the event was hijacked by the corporate interest groups. According to them the U.S., Japan and the oil companies once again discouraged the promotion of renewable energy sources like wind and solar power, in order to favour their own economic interests²¹.

In May 2003, ministers of environment set the goal to halt the loss of bio-diversity by 2010 at the Pan European Kyiv Ministerial Conference in the Kyiv Resolution on Bio-diversity along with other nine tangible targets.

In October 2004, Kenyan environmentalist, human rights activists and Deputy Environment Minister Mrs. W. Maathai won the Nobel Peace Prize. She is best known for her campaign called the “Green Belt Movement” that began in the 1970s and planted tens of millions of trees across Africa to slow deforestation. The movement grew to include projects to preserve bio-diversity, educate people about their environment and promote the rights of women and girls.

In November 2004, 300 scientists, who worked for four years on the international Arctic Council reported that rapid climate change is occurring in the Arctic. They concluded that the sea ice in the Arctic covered 10 percent less surface area than it had 30 years earlier and was only about half as thick as it had been then. Rapid melting of sea ice was threatening many species²².

Environmental Philosophy;

During the 1970s philosophers started taking interest in environmental issues and a new branch of ethics was born – “environmental philosophy” or simply environmentalism. Environmentalism is unique as a political ideology in its concern for the relationship between human beings and their environment as well as among human beings themselves. Environmental philosophy’s critique of the modern industrial society can be summarized by saying with Fritz Schumacher, author of *Small Is Beautiful*, that the “modern industrial system with all its intellectual sophistication consumes the very basis on which it has been erected”²³.

Environmental thought and ideologies, which are the bases upon which the edifice of the various offshoots of the environmental movement are erected can be broadly classified into philosophies – Anthropocentric philosophy and Bio-centric philosophy.

Anthropocentric (Human Centric) Philosophy; Also known as ‘Shallow Ecology’ or ‘Techno-centrism’, this philosophy includes mainly the negative effects that the environmental damages have on human being, their health, recreation and quality of life. It is in fact a mechanistic approach to non-human nature in which individual creatures and species have only an instrumental value for humans. Anthropocentric approach takes its support from the famous line of *The Holy Bible* (Genesis 1:27-8); “God created man in his own image, in the image of God created He him, male and female created He them, Be God blessed them, and God said to them, be fruitful and multiply and replenish the earth, and subdue it and have dominion over fish of the sea, and over fowl in the air, and over every thing that moveth upon the earth”²⁷. In fact this main strands of Christian thinking has encouraged the over exploitation of nature by maintaining superiority of humans over all other forms of life and by depicting all of nature as created for the use of humans. Similar opinion has been expressed by the Greek Philosopher Aristotle in his classic *Politics* (Book 1, chapter 8); “nature has made all things specifically for the sake of man” and the value of non-human things in nature is merely instrumental. The Christian philosopher Thomas Aquinas maintains in his *Summa Contra Gentiles* (Book 3, Part-2, Chapter-112) that because non-human animals are “ordered to man’s use”, he can kill them or use them in anyway he wishes without any injustice. Generally, anthropocentric positions recognizes the over exploitation of nature and cruel treatment of non-human animals as something wrong only when such human caused damages start affecting the well being of human beings, which is essentially dependent on a sustainable environment.

Critics of the anthropocentric school have charged that it amounts to a form of “human Chauvinism”. They argue that anthropocentrism presuppose the western view of nature as merely a resource to be managed or exploited for human purposes- a view according to them is responsible for centuries of environmental destruction²⁵.

Besides, anthropocentric approach, some earlier schools of environmental philosophy such as Apocalyptic (Survivalist) environmentalism and Emancipatory environmentalism – as well as its offshoot Human Welfare Ecology are primarily modeled on ideology of human well being.

Apocalyptic Environmentalism; The ideological stands of the environmental movements of 1960s and early 70s were generally pessimistic that the earth’s long-term prospects were bleak. Works such as Rachel Carson’s *Silent Spring* (1962), Garret Hardin’s *The Tragedy of the Commons* (1968), Paul Ehrlich’s *The Population Bomb*, Donella H. Meadow’s *The Limits of Growth* (1972) and Edward Goldsmith’s *Blueprint for Survival* (1972) suggested that the planetary ecosystem was reaching the limits of what it could sustain. These apocalyptic or survivalist literatures encouraged some environmentalists to call for an increase in the powers of the governments of different countries over human activities deemed environmentally harmful. Similar opinions were put forward most vividly in Robert Heilbroner’s *An Inquiry into the Human Prospects* (1974), in which he argued that survival of man ultimately required the curtailment of freedom. However, Heilbroner’s view regarding greater governmental interference was countered by Julian Simon and Herman Kahn in their 1984 publication *The Resourceful Earth*, where they emphasized man’s ability to find or to invent substitutes for resources that were scarce and in danger of being exhausted.²⁶.

Emancipatory Environmentalism; In the early 1970s, many environmentalists attempted to develop strategies for controlling environmental damages through recycling, the use of alternative energy technologies, the decentralization and democratization of economic and social planning and a reorganization of major industrial sectors including the agriculture and energy industries. Contrary to the apocalyptic school the emancipatory school took a more positive and practical approach, which included efforts to promote an ecological consciousness and environmental management. Some of the champions of emancipatory environmentalism put more emphasis on developing small scale system of economic production instead of big units, that would be more closely integrated with the natural process of surrounding ecosystems. This environmentally holistic approach to economic planning was promoted by an American ecologist Barry Commoner and German economist Ernst Friedrich Schumacher. The duo emphasized productive processes that worked with nature and not against it, encourages the use of organic and renewable resources rather than synthetic products such as plastics and chemical fertilizers and pesticides and the use of renewable and small-scale energy resources such as wind and solar power. This approach was called forth through the 1990s in the popular slogan,; “Think globally, act locally”²⁷.

Human-Welfare Ecology; This approach aims to enhance human life by creating a safe and cleaner environment and places more importance on quality of life than on traditional economic concerns. It was a part of a broader concern with distributive justice and reflected the tendency later characterized as post materialism.

Bio-centric Philosophy; Bio-centric philosophy claims that nature has an intrinsic moral worth that does not depend on its usefulness to human beings and it is this intrinsic worth that gives rise directly to obligations to the environment. Humans are therefore morally bound to protect the environment, as well as individual creatures and species, for their own sake. In this sense, bio-centric thinkers view human beings and other elements of the natural environment, both living and often non-living, as members of a single moral and ecological community.

Some later environmental movements like “social ecology”, “deep ecology”, “the animal rights” and “animal liberation movement” and “eco-feminism” were also based on similar ideology.

Social Ecology; Social ecology is a radical and counter-cultural concept and it traces the causes of environmental degradation to the existence of unjust, hierarchical relationship in human society, which is due to the large-scale social structure of modern capitalist state. Accordingly, they put forward their argument that the most environmentally sympathetic form of political and social organization is one based on decentralized small-scale communities and systems of production.

The main proponent of the concept of social ecology is the American environmental anarchist Murry Bookchin. He regards environmentalism as a social movement and the challenges it faces are in fact social problems, for which he favours human intervention. According to him human beings can choose to put themselves at the service of natural evolution to help maintain complexity and diversity, diminish suffering and reduce pollution. Bookchin recommends that a man should use his gifts of sociability, communication and intelligence to protect the natural environment. In other words oppression of nature should be replaced by a richer form of life devoted to nature’s preservation.

Deep Ecology; Deep Ecology is a radical doctrine based on preservationist themes from the early environmental movement. Its main originators, the Norwegian philosopher Arne Naess, the American philosopher George Sessions and the American sociologist Bill Devall, share with social ecologists a distrust of capitalism and industrial technology and favour decentralized forms of social organizations. Deep ecologists also claim that humans need to regain a “spiritual” relationship with non-human nature. By taking into account the interconnectedness of all organisms- including humans- in the ecosphere and identifying with non-human nature, according to them humans would develop an ecological consciousness and a sense of ecological solidarity. The bio-centric principle of interconnectedness was extensively developed by British environmentalist James Lovelock, who postulated in his *Gaia: A New Look at Life on Earth* (1979) that the planet earth is a single living, self regulating entity capable of re-establishing an ecological equilibrium even without the existence of human life.

Animal Rights; The emphasis on intrinsic value and the interconnectedness of nature was fundamental to the development of the animal rights movement. Peter Singer’s *Animal Liberation* (1977) and Tom Regan’s *The Case for Animal Rights* (1983) had great influence on the movement. Apart from ill treatment and cruelty to animals the members of the animal rights group demand an end to all forms of animal exploitation, including the use of animals in scientific and medical experiments such as in circuses and races.

Eco-Feminism; Oppression, hierarchy and spiritual relationship with nature have been the central concern of eco-feminism. Eco-feminists argue that there exists a connection between the destruction of nature of humans and the oppression of women by men as both women and nature are treated as objects to be owned and controlled. Eco-feminists aim to establish a central role for women in the pursuit of an environmentally sound and socially just society. However, there exists a division between them over how to conceive of the relationship between nature and women. Whereas cultural eco-feminists are of the view that the relationship is inherent in women’s reproductive and nurturing roles, social eco-feminism claim that it arises from social and cultural hierarchies that confine women primarily to the private sphere.

Some Terminologies Related to the Concept of Environmentalism;

Green Anarchism; Green anarchism is a diverse and open environmental philosophy which takes influences from a variety of different theories such as anarchism, social ecologism, feminism, egoism, surrealism, Luddite’s philosophy, primitivism, anti industrialism etc. It is often described as anti-civilization anarchism and anarcho-primitivism. Although, not all green anarchists anti-civilization and primitivists. The green anarchists target institution of dominion such as the state, capitalism, globalization, domestication, patriarchy and so on, which are inherently destructive and exploitative (to human and the environment). These institutions, according to them cannot be reformed. Hence they should be abolished. Green anarchism rejects progress through current political and legislative measures and favours direct and autonomous action, sabotage, insurrection, bioregionalism and reconnecting with the natural world to create meaningful change.

Green anarchists as often understood, do not advocate a return to the stone age or the replication of gatherer-hunter lifestyles, instead they advocate creation of new

communities which exist without the institutions of dominions while at the same time resists the current ones in place.

Eco-Anarchism; Eco-anarchism argues that small eco villages of no more than a few hundred people are the ideal place for living. They are of the opinion that infrastructure and political systems should be reorganized to ensure that such eco-villages are created. Eco-anarchists assert that social organizations must be designed to work with natural forces rather than against. Daniel Quinn's fiction *Ishmael* is considered to be the most important piece of eco-anarchist literature. Quinn's book contains conversations between a man and a gorilla. This book won the Turner Tomorrow Fellowship Award, created by Ted Turner, which rewarded an author, who came up with a new solution to environmental problem through fiction. However, Quinn denied any identification with anarchism. He stated; "I have made it abundantly clear that I admire the functionality of tribal societies- and they are certainly not anarchies"²⁸. Other writers arguing in favour of eco-anarchism include Derrick Jensen, Murray Bookchin and John Zerzan.

Political Ecology; Political ecology is a generic term for a variety of studies that involve "politics" and the "environment". These studies include;

- (a) attempts to analyze politics using the language and methods of ecology. In other words, like the species of plants and animals, societies and states can only be understood in terms of their place in a larger system including other societies and states.
- (b) An analysis of political struggles for control over natural resources or of political struggles whose outcome is determined by differential access to natural resources.
- (c) Research on biotic diversity and natural resource exploitation that is intended to inform public policy.

Within geography and anthropology political ecology involves elements of all three of the foregoing approaches. In both disciplines political ecology also refers to a specific attempt to bring together cultural ecology and political economy. However, by cultural ecology geographers and anthropologists mean different but complementary things. In general cultural ecology studies the relationship between a given society and its natural environment. But what geographers generally mean by the term cultural ecology is the study of how the natural environment affects the socially organized behaviours. Regarding political economy geographers and anthropologists call it the study of how different polities (states or societies) in different parts of a global structure through which one polity exploits another polity. This approach of political economy comes out of the works of Emmanuel Wallerstein and Andre Gunder Frank, who are of the opinion that European Development was made possible by the "underdevelopment of non-European societies.

Geographical and anthropological ecologists argue that a cultural ecology informed by political economy will:

- (a) Look at cultures not only in their natural environment but in their political environments as well.
- (b) Look at unequal relations among societies affect the natural environment.
- (c) Look at how unequal relations (especially class relations) within a culture affects the environment.

Eco-Terrorism; The term terrorism is typically used to describe the politically motivated acts of violence with the intention to intimidate governments or civilians. Acts meeting

these criteria and committed in the name of environmental causes are described as “eco-terrorism” by law enforcing agencies such as the FBI. The FBI Domestic Terrorism section defines eco-terrorism as “the use or threatened use of violence of a criminal nature against innocent civilians or property by an environmentally oriented sub-national group for politico-environmental reasons or aimed at an audience beyond the target, often of a symbolic nature”.

Some critics of the term “eco-terrorism” have argued that it should mean the opposite of its current accepted meaning. They are of the view that persons, companies and governments engaging in ecologically irresponsible activities such as pollution are committing terrors against the environment. They further claim that militant environmental groups are actually “eco-defender”. This counter definition is sometimes used rhetorically to express the environmentalist points of view, or to justify their action. Canadian environmentalist David Suzuki, for instance, has described the Prime Minister of Australia John Howard, as an eco-terrorist for failing to abide by the Kyoto Protocol on climate change.

The three groups most commonly labeled as “eco-terrorists” within the United States are the *Animal Liberation Front* (ALF), the *Earth Liberation Front* (ELF) and sometimes *Earth First*. Their websites all openly advocate tactics including arson, graffiti, vandalism and property destruction. Through their action they have destroyed millions of dollars of equipments and research centers (including medical research centers). *People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals* (PETA) has been financially linked to the foregoing “eco-terrorist” groups and has provided financial support to actions carried out in the name of ELF and ALF.

The Polluters Pay Principle; Since the early 1970s the polluters pay principle has been a dominant concept in the environmental law. It is believed that much environmental harm is caused by those producers who “externalize” the cost of their activities. For example, factories that emit unfiltered exhaust into the atmosphere or discharge untreated chemicals into a river pay little to dispose their waste. Instead the cost of waste disposal in the form of pollution is borne by the entire community. Accordingly, the purpose of many environmental regulations is to force polluters to bear the real costs of their pollution. In theory, such measures encourage producers of pollution to make cleaner product or to use cleaner technologies. The “Polluters Pay” principle underlies U.S. Laws requiring the cleaning of releases of hazardous substances, including oil. One such law the “Oil Pollution Act (1990) was passed in reaction to spillage of some 11 million gallons (41 million litres) of oil in Alaska in 1989. The “Polluter Pays” principle also guides the policies of the European Union and other government throughout world.

The Electoral Strategies of the Environmental Movement;

The electoral strategies of the environmental movement included the nomination of environmental candidates and the registration of green political parties. These parties were conceived of as a new kind of political organization that would bring the influence of the grass-root environmental movement to bear on the machinery of the government, make the environment a central concern of public policy and render the institutions of the state more democratic, transparent and accountable. The world’s oldest green parties- the *Values Party*, a nationally based party in New Zealand and the *United Tasmania Group*, organized in the Australian state of Tasmania- were founded in the early 1970s. The first

explicitly green member of a national legislature was elected in Switzerland in 1979, later in 1981, four greens won legislative seats in Belgium. The most successful environmental party has been the *German Green Party* founded in 1980. This party in 1998 formed a governing coalition with the *Social Democratic Party* and the party's leader Joschka Fischer was appointed as the country's foreign minister. However, this led to the fundamental elements in the *Green Party* to argue that the compromises necessary for electoral success invariably undermine the ethos of these environmental groups. By contrast, the party's realist elements accepted the need for coalition and compromises with other political parties, including traditional parties with views sometimes contrary to that of the *Green Party*.

By this time green parties have become broad political vehicles. In developing their party's programmes, they have applied the values of environmental philosophy to all issues facing their countries, including foreign policy, defence and social and economic policies.

Critiques of Environmentalism;

Some environmentalist groups have been accused of sensationalist tactics and misinforming the public instead of deferring to scientific evidence. Environmentalists are also sometimes accused of advocating anti-globalization and anti-corporatization idealism, which some say is detrimental to achieving environmental objectives. Michael Shellenberger and Ted Nordhaus, in the 2004 controversial essay- *The Death of Environmentalism*, have put forward the view that American environmentalism has been remarkably successful in protecting the air, water and large stretches of wilderness in North America and Europe, but has stagnated as a vital force for cultural and political change. They argued that the ecological crises the human species faces in the 21st century are qualitatively different from the problems the environmental movement was created to address in the 1960s and '70s. Climate change and habitat destruction, they argue are global, more complex and demand for deeper transformations of the economy, the culture and political life.

The bottom line of the entire analysis of the concept of environmentalism is that if the mankind realize their responsibility regarding nature, that is aptly expressed in the environmentalist slogan; "Think globally, act locally", they will make the planet worth living for the present as well as future generations. This idea is also vividly expressed in a United Nations slogan; "We have not inherited this earth from our forefathers' we have borrowed it from our children".

The Concept of Sustainable Development;

Sustainable development focuses on improving the quality of life for all the Earth's citizen without increasing the use of natural resources beyond the capacity of the environment to supply them indefinitely. It requires an understanding that inaction has consequences and that we must find innovative ways to change institutional structures and influence individual behaviour. It is about taking action, changing policy and practice at all levels, from the individual to international. It is in fact not a new idea. Many cultures over the course of human history have recognized the need for harmony between the environment, society and economy. What is new is an articulation of these ideas in the context of contemporary society.

Sustainable development is a fluid concept that will continue to evolve over time common characteristics underlie the many streams of thought. It emphasizes the need for:

- (1) Concern for equity and fairness- ensuring the rights of poor and the future generations.
- (2) Long term view- applying the precautionary principle.
- (3) Systems thinking- understanding the interconnections between environment, economy and society.

In addition, sustainable development strategies usually highlight the interplay between the local and the global, the developing and the developed and the need for cooperation within and between sectors. It is not a detailed plan of action. There is no one solution. Solution will defer between places and time and depend on the mix of values and resources. Approaching decision making from a sustainable development perspective requires undertaking a careful assessment of the strength of one's household, community, company or organization to determine priority action.

Definitions; Sustainable development means different things to different people, but most frequently quoted definition is from the 1987 World Commission on environment and Development Report *Our Common Future* (also known as Brundtland Report); "Sustainable development is development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own need"²⁹.

Australia's *National Strategy for Ecologically Sustainable Development 1992 (NSED)* defines ecologically sustainable development as "using, conserving and enhancing the community's resources so that ecological processes, on which life depends, are maintained and the total quality of life, now and in the future, can be increased."

The position of the United nations Environment Programme on the issue of sustainable development is: "The intensified and unsustainable demand for land, water marine and coastal resources resulting from the expansion of agriculture and uncontrolled urbanization lead to increased degradation of natural ecosystems and erode the life supporting systems that uphold human civilizations. Caring for natural resources and promoting their sustainable use is an essential response of the world community to ensure its own survival"³⁰.

According to Ashok Khosla; "Sustainable development.....promote essential use of resources, environmental harmony and a just and equitable social order, all at the same time and quickly without letting a small class of people capture all the wealth and then devising policies to help it trickle down to the long marginalized minority"³¹.

Towards Sustainable Development; Signs of severe stress on the interlocked global economic, environmental and social system are witnessed around the globe. The report of the United Nation's Environmental Programme 'GEO - 2000' also points out that the "time for a rational, well planned transition to a sustainable system is running out fast"³². the continuation of the business as usual approach to decision making increases the chance that the global system will crack and begin to crumble. Already the earth is faced with full-scale emergencies through fresh water shortages, tropical forest destruction, species extinction, urban air pollution and climate change. The 1987 Brundtland Report

recommended seven critical actions necessary to ensure a better quality of life for people throughout the globe³³;

- (1) Revive growth
- (2) Change the quality of growth
- (3) Meet essential needs and aspirations for jobs, food and energy, water and sanitation.
- (4) Ensure a sustainable level of population.
- (5) Conserve and enhance the resource base
- (6) Reorient technology and manage risk.
- (7) Include and combine environmental and economic considerations in decision-making.

These recommendations call to change our actions and to do things differently. In particular, they underscore a need to –

- (a) Produce differently- apply concepts of eco-efficiency and sustainable livelihoods.
- (b) Consume differently.
- (c) Organize ourselves differently- increase public participation while reducing corruption and roll back subsidies.

In 1992, leaders at the Earth Summit, Rio, built upon the framework of Brundtland Report to create agreements and conventions on critical issues such as climate change, desertification and deforestation. They also drafted a broad action strategy- *Agenda 21* as the work plan for environment and development issues for the coming decades.

Throughout the rest of 1990s, regional and sector wise sustainability plans have been developed. A wide variety of groups- ranging from businesses and municipal governments to international organizations such as the World Bank- have adopted and given it their own particular interpretations. These initiatives have increased our understanding of what sustainable development means within a variety of contexts.

Critical Analysis; Many environmentalists have criticized the term sustainable development as self-contradictory, claiming that economic policies based around growth and continued depletion of resources cannot be sustainable since that term implies since that term implies that resources remain constant. Resources such as petroleum are consumed much faster than they are created by natural processes and are continually being depleted. It is also argued that the term “sustainable development” is invented by business lobbies, to prove capitalism as ecologically friendly, and thereby placating the environmentalists. However, technologies such as renewable energy and recycling if carried out appropriately provide for growth in the economic sense.

India’s Environmental Policy;

In the Constitution of India, the Directive Principles Of State policy on environment has been mentioned in the Article 48A, introduced by the 42nd Constitution Amendment Act 1976. It reads; “The state shall endeavour to protect and improve the environment and to safeguard the forest and welfare of the country”. Likewise in the Fundamental Duties section Article 51A (g) also introduced by the same constitutional amendment act lays down protection of environment as one of the fundamental duties of every citizen.

In the First Assembly Meeting of Global Environment Facility (31 March 1998) the then Indian Prime Minister A.B.Vajpayee among other things candidly

mentions: “In some ways it is ironical that some of the achievements of the twentieth century themselves pose the challenge for the twenty first century. With almost six billion people inhabiting this earth and the global GDP approaching thirty trillion dollars, the pace of human economic activity is putting pressure on global life support systems. We witness the depletion of non-renewable natural resources, the continued destruction of life sustaining forests and illegal international trade in protected species of flora and fauna. There is an on-going depletion of our planet’s biological treasures and the threat of an acceleration in global warming and in the green house effect. In short, there is a rapid globalization of environmental destruction. The environmental impact of human activity is no longer restricted to man made national boundaries³⁴. He further says; “The problem of environmental degradation..... require the reestablishment of environmental ethics and values practiced in traditional societies, with economic development based on these issues. India, as one of the traditional societies, has always believed in the integrity and sacredness on the nature.....The age old philosophy of coexistence is not merely for co-existence of human beings, but it is in fact a basic premise for all living beings and of harmony within the cosmos. The delicate balance of nature has to be restored over, as we have to ensure co-existence of different life forms, between plants and animals and between nature and man”³⁵.

The National Environmental Policy 2004; The United Progressive Alliance government of Indian released its Draft National Environmental Policy (NEP) 2004 for public discussion in August 2004. The Draft Policy accords priority to conservation of life supporting system such as land, forest and water. The causes of land degradation in India are many, ranging from the direct (water and wind erosion, loss of forest cover and water logging) to the indirect (fragmentation of land holding, inadequate tenure rights, wasteful subsidies on agricultural inputs such as water and power).

Biodiversity conservation has received adequate attention in the NEP. While dealing with fresh water resources, the NEP expresses alarm over the wasteful and inefficient use of surface and ground water and suggests a number of actions that needs to be taken for conservation. The policy does not refer to levy of proper user charges to reflect water scarcity and calls for a review of the subsidies now being extended to the agricultural sector. Agriculture consumes nearly 80 percent of the country’s utilizable water.

The NEP also dwells on subjects such as air quality, mountain ecosystem, wetland conservation, creation of environment awareness among the masses and spreading environmental education.

Urbanization has a strong adverse impact on environmental quality. The NEP rightly starts with the premise that the environmental problems of India arise mainly out of its large and growing population. The assimilative capacity of the environment for wastes is seriously challenged by the pattern of population distribution. Currently about 30 percent of the country’s population lives in urban areas and this is projected to reach 40 percent in the not-too-distant future.

Critical Estimate of the NEP 2004; here are certain notable omissions in the NEP. Of these, energy has much relevance to environment particularly in the context of global warming. The day is not far off when India, the sixth largest emitter of greenhouse gasses (which cause global warming), would be compelled to accept some limits on its emissions. This possible development has to be viewed in the light of the country’s

growing energy needs. According to the “Hydro-carbon Vision 2020” prepared by the Planning Commission, even in 2020 the country will be dependent on fossil fuels such as coals and oils for a major share of its energy requirements. The implications of this prognosis for India’s contribution to global warming as well as on the air quality at home are clear. The first will enhance and the second will deteriorate. The NEP is silent on these developments.

The NEP’s prescription of adoption of “science based and traditional land-use practices” developed through research and development for combating land degradation is too vague and general. Further, land degradation is often the result of unsustainable and incompatible land use engineered by the market. The progressive deterioration of land once under cultivation into pastures and barren lands is a common feature in India. Two tragic manifestations of inappropriate land use are the spate of suicides in farming communities in Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka and the migration of the rural poor (eco-refugees as M.S.Swaminathan once described them) to urban areas in search of employment. Enough is known of the nature of the problem and of measures to mitigate it. What is needed is more extension of knowledge already available rather than more research.

Hence, after a thorough analysis one comes to the conclusion that the National environment Policy 2004 emphasizes that what is good for the environment is also good for the economy and the overall development of the country.

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